Without speaking out against Ulbricht, Erich Mielke also took a clear position at the twelfth session of the Central Committee. In siding with Honecker, he accused Brandt's government of failing to provide proof that it was 'honestly interested' in ensuring European security, peace and cooperation with the socialist states. 'On the contrary, under the cloak of willingness to reach an understanding […] it strives to find new and dangerous ways of penetrating the socialist states politically and ideologically.'

As it happened, Brandt's social-liberal coalition turned into an energetic force in West Germany. It expanded civil liberties, improved the welfare state and invested in education. Other important reforms included the protection of the environment, healthcare, an overhaul of the penal system and the pursuit of 'quality of life', which sought to combine the humanisation of the workplace with environmental and health protection. 'We want to become a nation of good neighbours,' Brandt explained, when outlining the core elements of his foreign policy as securing of peace through dialogue.

Relations with Moscow warmed when Brandt signed the nuclear non-proliferation Treaty in November 1969, which Kurt Georg Kiesinger's outgoing administration had declined to endorse. More was to follow. In treaties with the USSR and Poland in 1970, the FRG recognised the existing borders in Europe as inviolable, ending a long period of strain between the two countries. Brezhnev later observed that 'the normalisation of relations between the Soviet Union and the Federal Republic of Germany is one of the most important developments in Europe's post-war history'. Over time, systematic meetings at the summit level became a significant form of Soviet-West German cooperation. 'Experience shows,' Brezhnev said at a dinner in honour of Brandt,8 'that when top political leaders join competent experts in various fields in developing relations between two countries, this acts as a stimulant for all concerned to work more effectively and promptly'.9